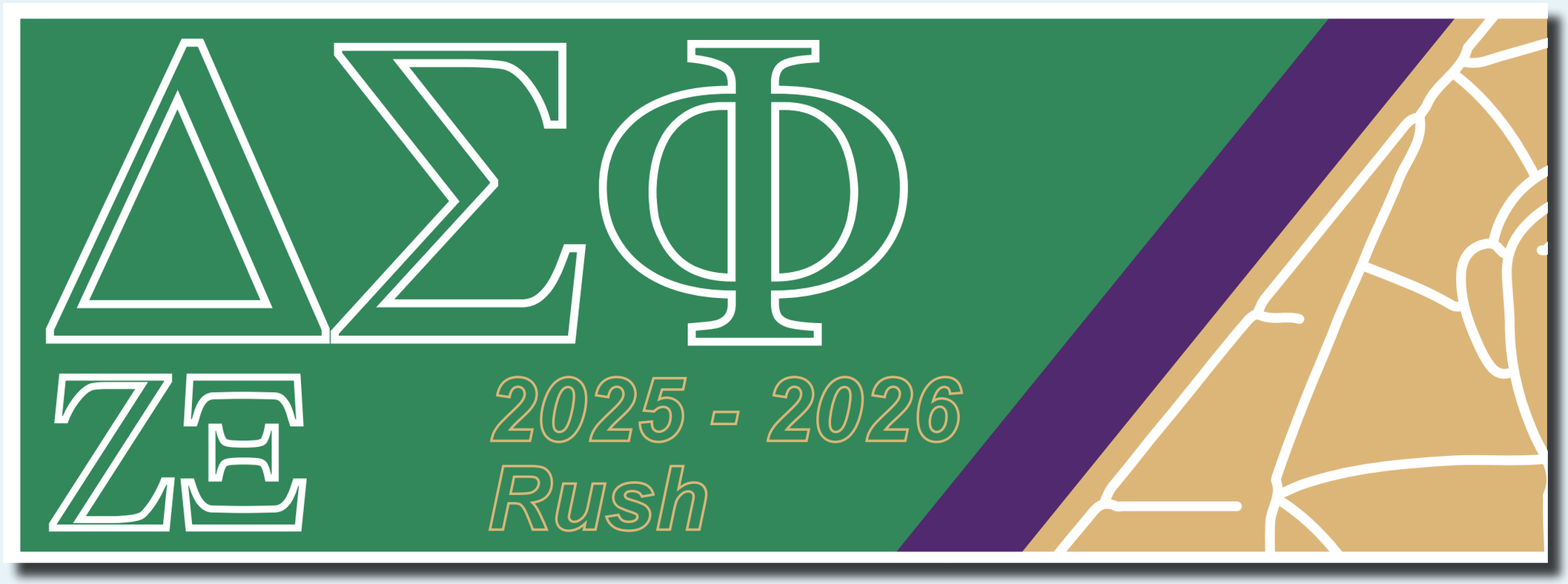
Sean Kelley
Work Examples
Graphic Designer

1|Delta Sigma Phi Rush Banner

9’ x 18’ banner to promote the fraternity



2| Delta Sigma Phi Rush Banner

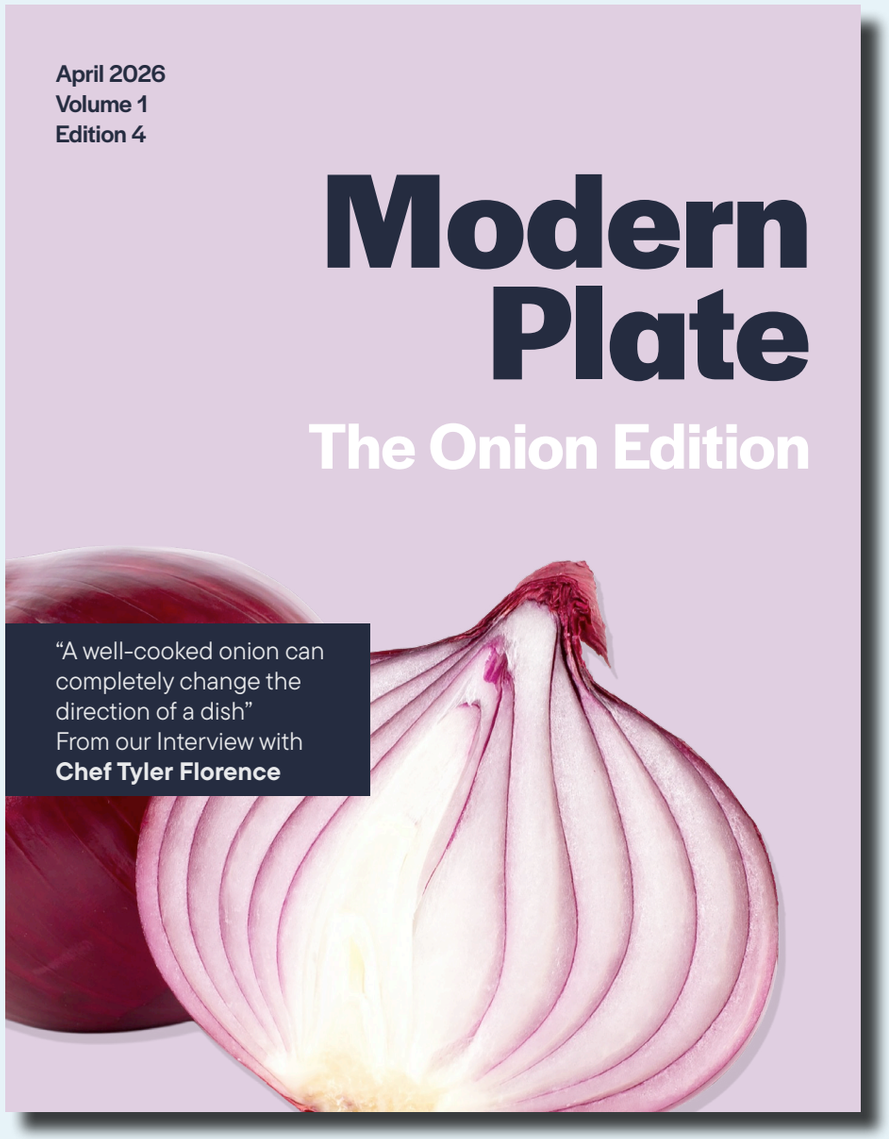
9’ x 18’ banner to promote the fraternity

3 | Modern Plate Magazine

8.5” x 11” cooking and food magazine (mockup)

4 | Modern Plate Magazine

8.5” x 11” cooking and food magazine



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In Conversation-

Tyler Florence

The Power of Onions

Kyle Hoffmann

Few ingredients are as foundational, or as underestimated, as the onion. To explore its versatility, Modern Plate sat down with **Chef Tyler Florence**, known for his approachable yet elevated take on classic cooking. From building flavor to refining technique, Florence shared how this everyday ingredient continues to shape his kitchen.

Modern Plate: Onions show up in almost everything, what makes them so essential?

Tyler Florence: They’re the starting point for flavor. When you cook onions properly, especially at the beginning of a dish, you’re building a base that everything else sits on. It’s not just about taste, it’s about depth, aroma, and balance. A well-cooked onion can completely change the direction of a dish.

MP: Do you have a favorite type of onion to work with?

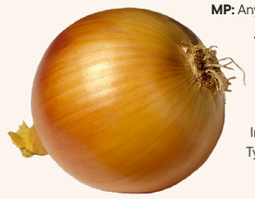
TF: Yellow onions are probably the most versatile, they’re my go-to. But I think the real key is understanding what each onion does. Red onions are great raw, shallots are perfect for more delicate sauces, and sweet onions can really shine when you let them caramelize. It’s about matching the onion to the technique.

MP: What’s the biggest mistake home cooks make when cooking onions?

TF: Rushing them. People crank the heat too high and try to get color quickly, but that’s not how you build flavor. You’ve got to give onions time to break down and develop that natural sweetness. Low and slow, that’s where the magic happens.

MP: Your take on French onion soup is a fan favorite. What’s your philosophy behind it?

TF: It all comes down to the onions. You’ve got to take the time to caramelize them properly, that’s where the entire flavor of the soup comes from. I like to push them really far, almost to the edge of deep brown, without burning. Then it’s about layering; good stock, a little wine, fresh herbs. And of course, the bread and cheese at the end, that’s what brings it all together.



MP: Any final advice for home cooks looking to get more out of onions?

TF: Treat them with a little more respect. They’re not just something you throw in at the beginning, they’re an ingredient you can build a dish around. If you learn how to cook onions well, you’re already halfway to becoming a better cook.

In kitchens around the world, onions may not always take center stage, but as Tyler Florence reminds us, they’re often the reason a dish works at all.

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Jake Paschke

Slow Alchemy:

Caramelized onions are one of the simplest ways to transform an everyday ingredient into something deeply rich, sweet, and complex. With just time, heat, and a bit of patience, sharp, pungent onions mellow into a golden, jammy mixture that can elevate everything from burgers and pastas to soups and sandwiches. While the process is straightforward, the magic lies in letting the onions cook slowly, allowing their natural sugars to develop and intensify. Think of it less as cooking and more as coaxing flavor out, layer by layer.

Classic Caramelized Onions

Ingredients:

- 3–4 large yellow onions
- 2 tablespoons butter (or olive oil)
- 1 teaspoon salt
- Optional: 1 teaspoon sugar (to speed up browning)
- Optional: 1–2 tablespoons water, broth, or balsamic vinegar (for deglazing)

Instructions:

1. Slice the onions

Peel and cut the onions in half from root to tip, then slice them thinly into even strips.

2. Heat the pan

Place a large skillet or sauté pan over medium heat. Add the butter or oil and let it melt.

3. Add the onions

Toss in the sliced onions and stir to coat them evenly in the fat. Sprinkle with salt.

4. Cook low and slow

Reduce heat to medium-low. Let the onions cook, stirring occasionally, for about 30–45 minutes. They will gradually soften, release moisture, and begin to brown.

5. Stir and scrape

As the onions cook, bits may stick to the pan—this is flavor. Stir and scrape frequently to prevent burning.

6. Deglaze (optional)

If the pan starts to get too dark, add a splash of water, broth, or balsamic vinegar to lift the browned bits and deepen the flavor.

7. Finish

Continue cooking until the onions are deeply golden brown, soft, and jam-like in texture. Taste and adjust seasoning if needed.

The Art of Caramelized Onions

Tip:

Patience is everything—rushing the heat will burn the onions instead of caramelizing them. Low and slow is the key to unlocking their natural sweetness.

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Know Your Onions:

A Guide to Flavor, Function & Form

Jody Baker

Onions are the quiet backbone of cooking—rarely the star, but almost always essential. What many home cooks overlook, however, is that not all onions behave the same. Each variety brings its own balance of sweetness, sharpness, moisture, and texture, meaning the difference between a good dish and a great one can come down to choosing the right onion for the job. From crisp, peppery bites to slow-cooked sweetness, understanding when to use each type unlocks a whole new level of control in the kitchen.

Yellow Onions - The All-Purpose Workhorse

If you could only keep one onion in your kitchen, this would be it. Yellow onions strike a balance between sharpness and sweetness, making them incredibly versatile.

Best for:

- Soups, stews, and stocks
- Caramelizing
- Roasting and sautéing

Why they work:

Yellow onions have a higher sulfur content, which gives them that classic “onion bite” when raw. But with heat, those compounds break down, revealing a deep, rich sweetness—perfect for dishes that cook low and slow.

Quick fact:

Most recipes that simply call for “onion” are referring to yellow onions by default.

White Onions - Clean, Sharp, and Bright

White onions have a more straightforward, slightly sharper flavor than yellow onions, with a crisp texture and a cleaner finish.

Best for:

- Salsas and fresh sauces
- Mexican and Latin American dishes
- Quick sautés

Why they work:

Their sharper bite cuts through rich or fatty foods, adding brightness without overwhelming the dish. They also tend to have a higher water content, which helps them soften quickly when cooked.

Quick fact:

White onions are a staple in many traditional salsas because their flavor stays bold even when mixed with acidic ingredients like lime juice.

Red Onions - Bold Color, Milder Bite

Red onions are known for their vibrant color and slightly milder flavor compared to yellow and white onions.

Best for:

- Salads and sandwiches
- Pickling
- Garnishes

Why they work:

They’re crisp and less pungent when raw, making them ideal for dishes where the onion isn’t cooked. Their color also adds visual contrast, which is especially valuable in fresh preparations.

Quick fact:

Soaking sliced red onions in cold water for a few minutes can mellow their sharpness while keeping their crunch.

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Sweet Onions - Mild and Sugary

Varieties like Vidalia, Walla Walla, and Maui onions fall into this category. They’re noticeably sweeter and less pungent than other types.

Best for:

- Onion rings or blooming onions
- Grilling
- Eating raw

Why they work:

Sweet onions have a lower sulfur content and higher natural sugar levels, which means they caramelize quickly and taste mild even when uncooked.

Quick fact:

Because of their higher water content, sweet onions don’t store as long as other varieties, best to use them sooner rather than later.

Shallots - Subtle and Sophisticated

Shallots are smaller, more delicate, and slightly sweeter than standard onions, with a hint of garlic-like complexity.

Best for:

- Salad dressings and vinaigrettes
- Sauces (especially French cuisine)
- Finishing dishes

Why they work:

Their refined flavor doesn’t overpower other ingredients, making them perfect for dishes where balance and nuance matter.

Quick fact:

Shallots are a favorite in fine dining because they blend seamlessly into sauces without dominating the flavor profile.

Green Onions (Scallions) - Fresh and Grassy

Green onions consist of a small white bulb and long green stalks, both of which are edible.

Best for:

- Garnishes
- Stir-fries
- Light, fresh dishes

Why they work:

They bring a mild onion flavor with a fresh, almost grassy note. The white part is slightly stronger, while the green tops are more delicate.

Quick fact:

In many Asian cuisines, green onions are used both as a cooking ingredient and a finishing touch.

Leeks - Mild, Sweet, and Silky

Leeks are technically part of the onion family, though they look and behave quite differently.

Best for:

- Soups (like potato leek)
- Braising
- Cream-based dishes

Why they work:

Leeks have a very mild, slightly sweet flavor that becomes silky when cooked. They add depth without the sharpness of traditional onions.

Quick fact:

Leeks grow in sandy soil, so they need thorough cleaning—dirt often hides between their layers.

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Choosing the Right Onion

At its core, choosing an onion comes down to one question: How do you want it to taste?

- For depth and richness: go with yellow onions
- For brightness and bite: reach for white onions
- For raw crunch and color: use red onions
- For sweetness: choose sweet onions
- For subtlety: opt for shallots or leeks
- For freshness: finish with green onions

Understanding these differences allows you to cook with intention. Instead of treating onions as interchangeable, you begin to use them as tools—each one suited to a specific role in building flavor.

In the end, onions are more than just a base—they’re a spectrum. Sharp or sweet, bold or delicate, raw or transformed by heat, they offer endless possibilities. Mastering their differences is one of the simplest ways to elevate your cooking, turning everyday meals into something more thoughtful, more balanced, and unmistakably Modern Plate.

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History of the Onion

Alexzander Good

The onion is one of the oldest cultivated foods in human history, a humble bulb that has traveled across continents, cultures, and centuries to become a global culinary staple. Its story is deeply intertwined with the development of agriculture, trade, medicine, and even religion.

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Archaeological evidence suggests that wild onions were consumed by prehistoric humans long before organized agriculture emerged. Unlike many early crops that required careful domestication, onions were naturally abundant and relatively easy to harvest, making them an accessible food source for early human communities. Their strong flavor and pungent aroma likely distinguished them from other wild plants, while their natural chemical compounds may have helped deter pests and preserve the bulb itself. These characteristics made onions not only edible but practical—qualities that encouraged their continued use and eventual cultivation.

As humans began to settle into agricultural societies during the Neolithic period, onions emerged as one of the earliest domesticated crops. Scholars often point to Central Asia, particularly regions corresponding to modern-day Iran, Afghanistan, and Pakistan, as the likely origin of cultivated onions. In these areas, early farmers experimented with plant cultivation, selecting for traits such as size, flavor, and storage potential. Onions proved particularly valuable because they could be dried and stored for months, providing a reliable food source during times when fresh produce was scarce.

The onion’s durability made it a natural companion to the growth of trade. As early trade routes developed, onions were among the goods transported between regions.

Their ability to survive long journeys without spoiling allowed them to spread rapidly across continents.

The Egyptians would worship onions, and they’re important to their beliefs

Along routes that would later become part of the Silk Road, onions moved alongside spices, grains, and textiles, gradually embedding themselves into the culinary traditions of distant cultures.

In ancient Mesopotamia, widely considered one of the birthplaces of civilization, onions were a dietary staple. Clay tablets written in cuneiform reference agricultural practices that included onion cultivation, and they appear frequently in records of food distribution. Onions were consumed by all levels of society, from laborers to elites, often combined with grains such as barley to create simple yet nourishing meals. Their role extended beyond sustenance; onions were also recognized for their medicinal value, believed to support digestion and overall health.

Ancient Egypt offers one of the most vivid examples of the onion’s cultural and symbolic importance. Egyptians were deeply attuned to symbolism in the natural world, and the onion’s layered, circular structure came to represent eternity and the cyclical nature of life and death. This symbolism was reflected in religious practices and burial rituals. Archaeologists have discovered onions placed in tombs, used as offerings to the dead, and even incorporated into mummification practices. In the case of Ramesses IV, onions were found placed within the mummy’s eye sockets, suggesting a belief that they could restore sight or provide spiritual protection in the afterlife.

Onions also played a practical role in Egyptian society. Laborers who built monumental structures like the pyramids were often compensated with food, including onions, garlic, and radishes. These foods were valued not only for their nutritional content but also for their ability to be stored and transported efficiently. The inclusion of onions in workers’ diets highlights their importance as both a staple food and a form of economic currency.

In ancient Persia, onions were deeply integrated into both cuisine and medicine. Persian cooking, known for its balance of flavors and emphasis on aromatic ingredients, often relied on onions as a foundational element. They were sautéed, stewed, and combined with herbs and spices to create complex dishes. Persian physicians also recognized onions for their potential health benefits, prescribing them for a variety of ailments. This dual role as both food and medicine contributed to the onion’s enduring significance in the region.

India presents a particularly rich and complex history of onion use. References to onions appear in ancient Sanskrit texts, where they are described both as a food and as a medicinal substance. However, onions also occupied a controversial place in certain religious traditions. In some interpretations of Hinduism and Jainism, onions were considered to have properties that could overstimulate the senses or disrupt spiritual discipline. As a result, their consumption was sometimes restricted among devout practitioners.

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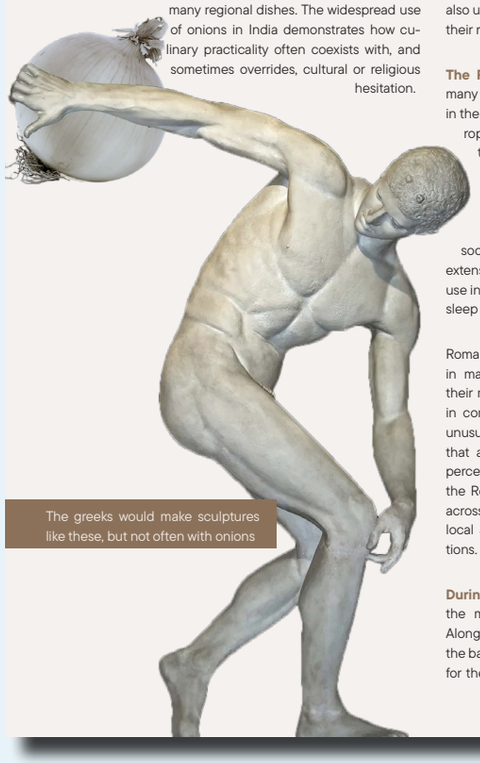
Despite these restrictions, onions became indispensable in Indian cuisine. They form the base of countless dishes, particularly in the preparation of curries, where they are often cooked slowly to develop deep, rich flavors. Techniques such as caramelization and frying onions in oil or ghee are central to Indian cooking, creating layers of taste that define many regional dishes. The widespread use of onions in India demonstrates how culinary practicality often coexists with, and sometimes overrides, cultural or religious hesitation.



The greeks would make sculptures like these, but not often with onions

In ancient Greece, onions were associated with strength, endurance, and vitality. Greek athletes consumed onions in various forms, raw, cooked, or as juice, believing they could improve physical performance. This belief reflects the broader Greek interest in diet and its impact on the body, a concept that would influence later medical traditions. Onions were also used in remedies for ailments, reinforcing their reputation as a health-promoting food.

The Romans adopted and expanded upon many Greek practices, playing a crucial role in the dissemination of onions throughout Europe. Roman soldiers carried onions with them as they traveled, introducing the crop to new territories across the empire. The Romans cultivated multiple varieties of onions and incorporated them into their cuisine at all levels of society. The naturalist Pliny the Elder wrote extensively about onions, documenting their use in treating conditions such as toothaches, sleep disorders, and digestive issues.

Roman gladiators were said to use onion juice in massages, believing it would strengthen their muscles and improve their performance in combat. While such practices may seem unusual today, they illustrate the deep trust that ancient cultures placed in the onion's perceived medicinal and physical benefits. As the Roman Empire expanded, onions spread across Europe, becoming firmly embedded in local agricultural systems and culinary traditions.

During the Middle Ages, onions were among the most important vegetables in Europe. Alongside cabbage and beans, they formed the backbone of the medieval diet, particularly for the lower classes. Their affordability, availability, and nutritional value made them indispensable. Onions were used in a wide range of dishes, from simple broths to more elaborate preparations for the nobility.

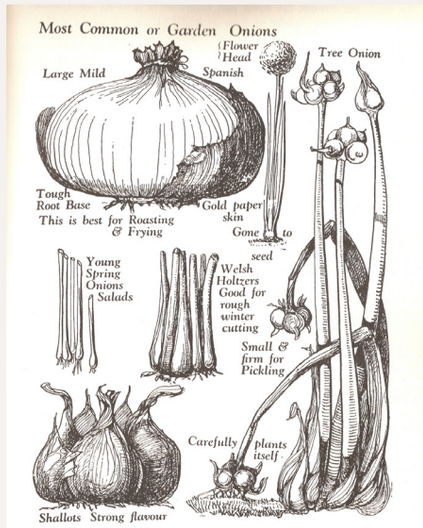
Beyond their culinary uses, onions held economic significance in medieval society. They were sometimes used as a form of payment, given as rent to landowners, or exchanged as gifts. In some cases, onions were even included in dowries, highlighting their perceived value. Monasteries and rural farms cultivated onions extensively, ensuring a steady supply for both local consumption and trade.

In East Asia, onions and related alliums such as scallions and leeks played an important role in both cuisine and medicine. In China, green onions became a staple ingredient, used to add flavor and aroma to a wide variety of dishes. Traditional Chinese medicine incorporated onions as a remedy for colds, coughs, and respiratory conditions, emphasizing their warming properties. These practices reflect a broader global pattern in which onions were valued not only for their taste but also for their perceived health benefits.

Japan and Korea also incorporated onions and similar plants into their culinary traditions. While the bulb onion became more prominent in these regions at a later stage, related alliums had long been used in soups, broths, and vegetable dishes. The integration of onions into East Asian cuisines illustrates their adaptability and their ability to complement a wide range of flavors and cooking techniques.

The Age of Exploration marked a new chapter in the history of the onion. As European explorers traveled to the Americas, they brought onions with them, introducing the crop to new environments. Onions adapted well to the diverse climates of the New World, quickly becoming a staple in colonial agriculture. European settlers valued onions for their practicality, as they were easy to grow and could be stored for extended periods.

Indigenous peoples of the Americas were already familiar with wild onions and similar plants, which they had been harvesting for generations. The introduction of cultivated onions complemented these existing practices, leading to a blending of culinary traditions. Over time, onions became deeply integrated into the cuisines of North, Central, and South America.



A medieval diagram of an onion

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In colonial North America, onions were a common feature of home gardens and farm plots. They were used in soups, stews, and meat dishes, providing a reliable source of flavor and nutrition. As American cuisine evolved, onions remained a constant presence, adapting to new influences and ingredients. Today, they are a key component of many iconic dishes, from burgers and hot dogs to regional specialties like gumbo and chili.

In Latin America, onions are essential to many traditional dishes. They are often used in combination with tomatoes, peppers, and herbs to create salsas, sauces, and rice dishes. This combination of ingredients reflects the blending of indigenous and European culinary traditions, with onions serving as a unifying element. Their ability to enhance and balance flavors has made them indispensable across the region.

African cuisines also feature onions prominently. In North Africa, onions are a key ingredient in tagines and stews, where they are often slow-cooked to develop sweetness and depth.

Native American onion farmers

Onions: Taking over the world!

In sub-Saharan Africa, onions are used in a variety of savory dishes, from soups to rice-based meals. Their versatility and availability have made them a staple across the continent.

Throughout history, onions have maintained a strong presence in traditional medicine. Many cultures have used them to treat ailments such as colds, infections, and inflammation. Modern science has identified compounds in onions that possess antioxidant and antimicrobial properties, lending some support to these traditional practices. While onions are no longer viewed as cure-alls, they continue to be recognized as a nutritious and health-promoting food.

In the modern world, onions are cultivated on a global scale and are a fundamental ingredient in countless cuisines. They are grown in a wide range of climates, from temperate regions to tropical areas, and are available year-round in many parts of the world. Advances in agriculture and transportation have made onions more accessible than ever, further cementing their place in global diets.

Onions are also remarkably versatile in the kitchen. They can be eaten raw, adding sharpness and crunch to salads and sandwiches, or cooked in a variety of ways to bring out different flavors. Caramelized onions, for example, develop a rich sweetness that contrasts with their raw pungency. Pickled onions add acidity and brightness, while fried onions provide texture and depth.

Culturally, onions continue to hold significance in many parts of the world. They appear in traditional dishes associated with holidays and celebrations, reflecting their enduring role in communal and family life. From French onion soup to Indian curries, Chinese stir-fries, and countless other dishes, onions serve as a foundation upon which culinary traditions are built.

The history of the onion is, ultimately, a story of resilience and adaptability. It is a story of how a simple plant can travel across continents, integrate into diverse cultures, and remain relevant across millennia. Onions have been cultivated by ancient farmers, traded by merchants, studied by physicians, and cherished by cooks. They have nourished civilizations, influenced economies, and inspired traditions.

Layer by layer, the onion reveals a history that is both complex and deeply human. It connects us to our past, reminding us of the shared practices and innovations that have shaped our world. Though often overlooked in favor of more glamorous ingredients, the onion stands as a testament to the enduring importance of the everyday—a quiet yet essential presence in the story of human civilization.

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Depth & Comfort - A Classic French Onion Soup

Chloe Shaw

Few dishes capture comfort and depth of flavor quite like French onion soup. What began as a humble, resourceful meal, built from simple ingredients like onions, bread, and broth—has become one of the most iconic dishes in French cuisine. Its magic lies in transformation: slowly caramelized onions create a rich, deeply savory base, which is then topped with toasted bread and melted cheese for a perfect balance of texture and flavor. Whether served as a starter or the star of the table, this dish proves that patience and simplicity can create something truly extraordinary.

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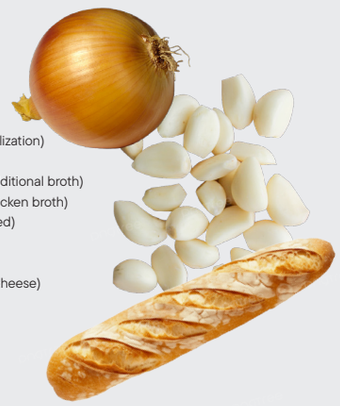
Classic French Onion Soup

Serves: 4–6
Time: About 1 hour 30 minutes

Ingredients:

- 4 large yellow onions, thinly sliced
- 3 tablespoons unsalted butter
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 1 teaspoon salt
- ½ teaspoon black pepper
- 1 teaspoon sugar (optional, to help caramelization)
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- ½ cup dry white wine (or substitute with additional broth)
- 6 cups beef broth (or a mix of beef and chicken broth)
- 1 teaspoon fresh thyme (or ½ teaspoon dried)
- 1 bay leaf
- 1 baguette, sliced into rounds
- 1½ cups grated Gruyère cheese (or Swiss cheese)



Instructions:

1. Caramelize the onions

In a large pot or Dutch oven, melt the butter with olive oil over medium heat. Add the sliced onions, salt, and pepper. Cook, stirring occasionally, for 30–40 minutes over medium-low heat until the onions are deeply golden and caramelized. Add sugar if desired to help them brown. You can read more about caramelizing onions on page 4.

2. Add garlic and deglaze

Stir in the minced garlic and cook for about 1 minute. Pour in the white wine, scraping up any browned bits from the bottom of the pot. Let it simmer for 2–3 minutes until slightly reduced.

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3. Build the soup

Add the broth, thyme, and bay leaf. Bring to a gentle simmer and cook uncovered for 20–30 minutes to develop flavor. Remove the bay leaf and taste, adjusting seasoning as needed.

4. Prepare the bread

While the soup simmers, toast the baguette slices in the oven at 400°F (200°C) until crisp and lightly golden.

5. Assemble and broil

Ladle the soup into oven-safe bowls. Place a slice (or two) of toasted baguette on top of each, then generously cover with grated Gruyère cheese. Place the bowls under a broiler until the cheese is melted, bubbly, and lightly browned.

6. Serve immediately

Carefully remove from the oven and let cool slightly before serving, the bowls will be very hot.

Tip:

For the deepest flavor, take your time with the onions. The longer and slower they cook, the richer and more complex your soup will be.

Images from *French Onion Soup | Basics with Babish*, Binging with Babish

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Crisp & Shareable - The Blooming Onion Reimagined

Sally Reeke

Few appetizers make an entrance quite like the blooming onion. With its dramatic, flower-like shape and irresistibly crispy petals, it’s as much a centerpiece as it is a snack. Popularized in American steakhouses, the blooming onion takes a simple ingredient and turns it into something indulgent, crunchy, and perfect for dipping. Beneath the crisp, seasoned coating is a tender onion that pulls apart effortlessly—designed for sharing, though it’s hard not to keep reaching for just one more piece.

While it may look complicated, making a blooming onion at home is surprisingly achievable with a bit of careful slicing and a good frying setup. The reward is a restaurant-quality appetizer that’s hot, crunchy, and deeply satisfying.

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Modern Blooming Onion

Serves: 2–4
Time: About 45 minutes

Ingredients:

For the onion:

- 1 large sweet onion (like Vidalia)
- 3–4 cups vegetable oil (for frying)

For the coating:

- 1 cup all-purpose flour
- 2 teaspoons paprika
- 1 teaspoon garlic powder
- 1 teaspoon onion powder
- ½ teaspoon cayenne pepper (optional)
- 1 teaspoon salt
- ½ teaspoon black pepper
- ½ teaspoon Old Bay Seasoning

For the batter:

- 2 eggs
- 1 cup milk

For the dipping sauce:

- ½ cup mayonnaise
- 2 tablespoons ketchup
- 1 tablespoon prepared horseradish
- ½ teaspoon paprika
- ¼ teaspoon garlic powder
- Salt and pepper to taste

Instructions:

1. Prep the onion

Peel the onion and cut off about ½ inch from the top (not the root end). Place the onion cut-side down. Starting about ½ inch from the root, make 12–16 vertical cuts down to create “petals,” being careful not to cut all the way through the root. Gently separate the layers with your fingers to create the blooming effect.

2. Soak (optional but helpful)

Place the onion in cold water for 10–15 minutes to help the petals open up further. Remove and pat completely dry.

3. Prepare the coating

In a large bowl, mix the flour, paprika, garlic powder, onion powder, cayenne, salt, and pepper.

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4. Make the batter

In another bowl, whisk together the eggs and milk.

5. Coat the onion

Carefully dredge the onion in the flour mixture, making sure to get in between all the petals. Shake off excess, then dip the onion into the egg mixture. Return it to the flour mixture for a second coating, ensuring it’s well covered.

6. Heat the oil

In a deep pot, heat the oil to 350°F (175°C). The oil should be deep enough to fully submerge the onion.

7. Fry the onion

Carefully place the onion into the oil, cut-side down. Fry for about 5–7 minutes, then flip and fry for another 3–5 minutes until golden brown and crispy.

8. Drain and rest

Remove the onion and place it on paper towels to drain excess oil.

9. Make the sauce

Mix all dipping sauce ingredients in a small bowl until smooth. Adjust seasoning to taste.

10.Serve immediately

Place the blooming onion on a serving plate with the dipping sauce in the center or on the side. Pull apart and enjoy while hot and crispy.

Images from *How to make a How to make a Blooming Onion*, Dont Go Bacon My Heart

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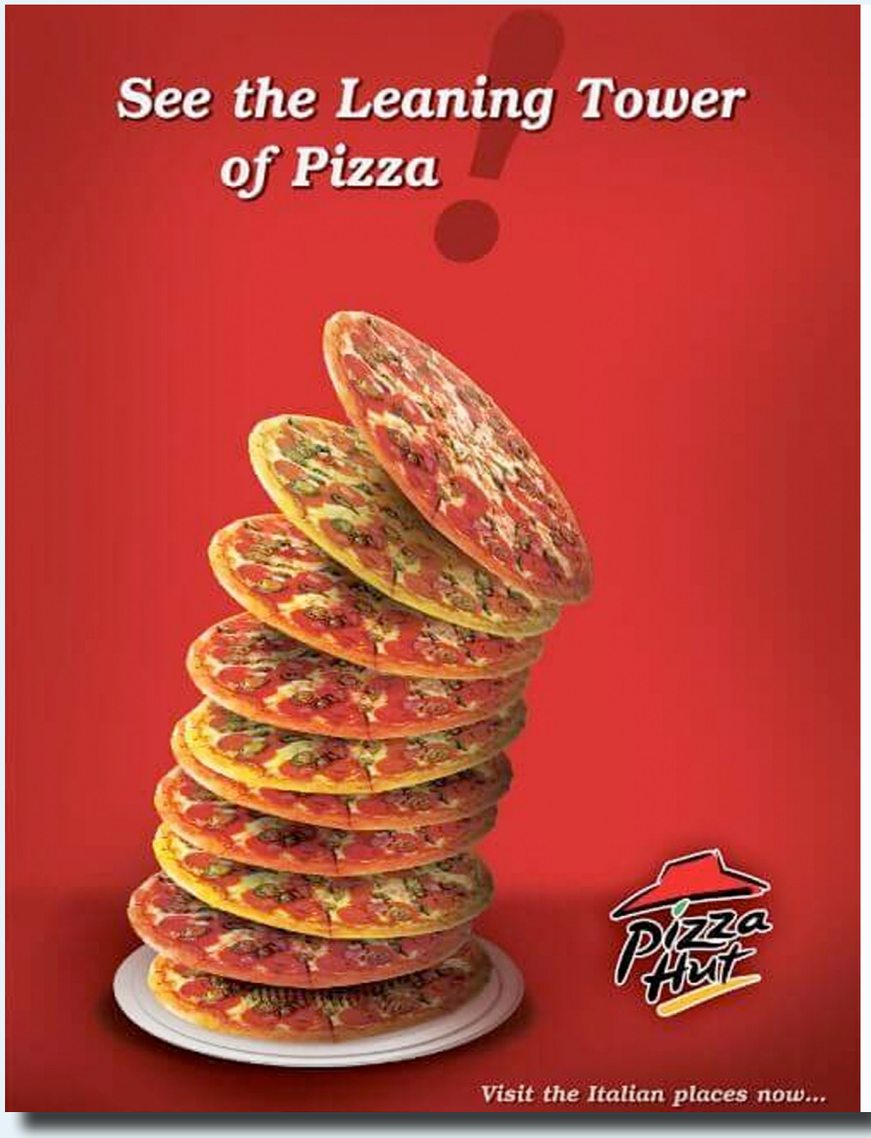


Modern Editorial: In Praise of the Onion

Sean Kelley

There’s a quiet kind of magic in the ingredients we think we already understand. The ones we reach for without thinking. The ones that show up in nearly every dish, yet rarely receive the attention they deserve. For this issue of Modern Plate, we chose to focus on one of the most familiar—and most overlooked—ingredients in the kitchen: the onion.

At first glance, it might seem like an unusual centerpiece. Onions aren’t flashy. They don’t carry the prestige of luxury ingredients or the novelty of fleeting food trends. They don’t demand attention on a plate. But that’s precisely the point. The onion is foundational. It’s the starting note in countless recipes, the quiet builder of flavor that works behind the scenes. And when you stop to really consider it, you begin to realize just how much of cooking depends on this single, layered vegetable.

This issue is an invitation to slow down and look closer. To think about what happens when onions hit a hot pan—the way they soften, release their aroma, and gradually transform from sharp and biting to rich and sweet. It’s a process that asks for patience, something increasingly rare in modern cooking. In a world that often prioritizes speed and convenience, onions remind us that some of the best flavors can’t be rushed.

But beyond technique, onions tell a much larger story. They connect cuisines, cultures, and histories. From deeply caramelized bases in French cooking to the aromatic foundations of Indian curries, from fresh salsas to slow-simmered stews, onions are everywhere. They adapt, they absorb, they enhance. They are both universal and deeply personal—shaped by the hands and traditions that use them.

What makes onions especially compelling is their range. Few ingredients can move so effortlessly between roles. Raw, they bring sharpness and bite. Cooked quickly, they add brightness and structure. Given time, they become something entirely different—soft, sweet, and complex. That transformation is at the heart of cooking itself: taking something simple and revealing its full potential.

In this issue, you’ll find that idea explored from multiple angles. We’ve looked at technique, from mastering caramelization to understanding how different onion varieties behave in the kitchen. We’ve celebrated classics, like French onion soup, while also embracing the playful and indulgent, like the blooming onion. And we’ve spoken with chefs who understand that even the most humble ingredient deserves intention.

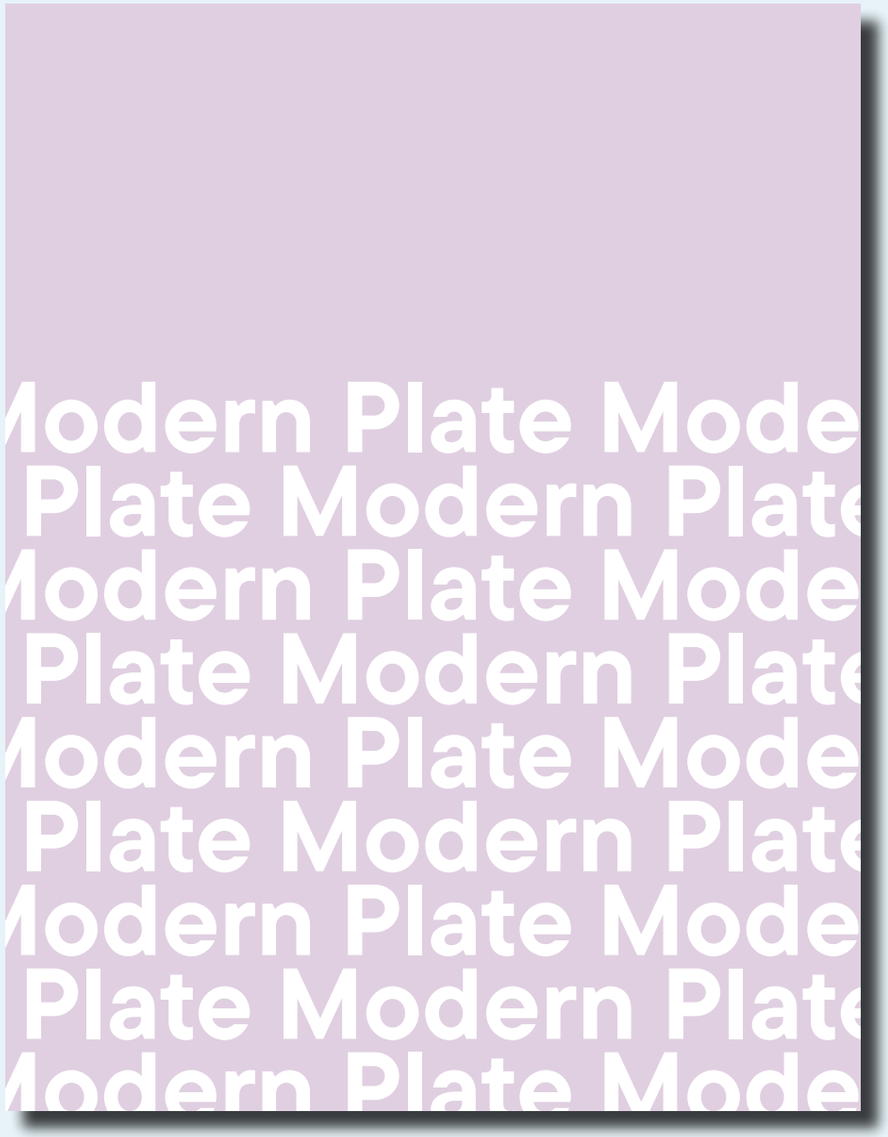
Modern Plate has always been about finding meaning in the details—about elevating everyday cooking through awareness, curiosity, and care. The onion embodies all of that. It asks very little of us, yet gives so much in return.

So this month, we encourage you to pay attention to what’s already in your kitchen. Slice an onion and notice its structure. Cook it slowly and watch it change. Taste it at every stage. There’s a story there—one that unfolds layer by layer.

And sometimes, that’s all great cooking really is.

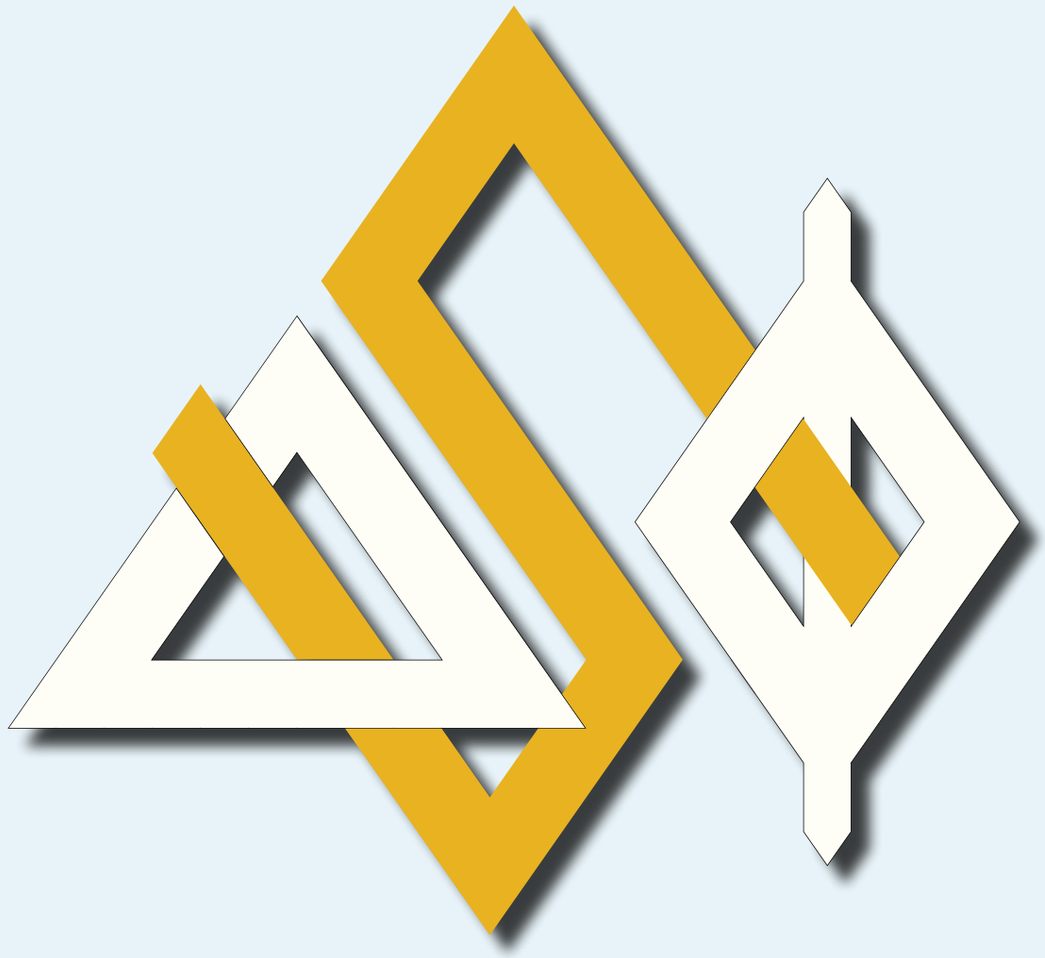
22|Modern Plate Magazine

8.5” x 11” cooking and food magazine



23| Delta Sigma Phi Branding

300px logo for social media

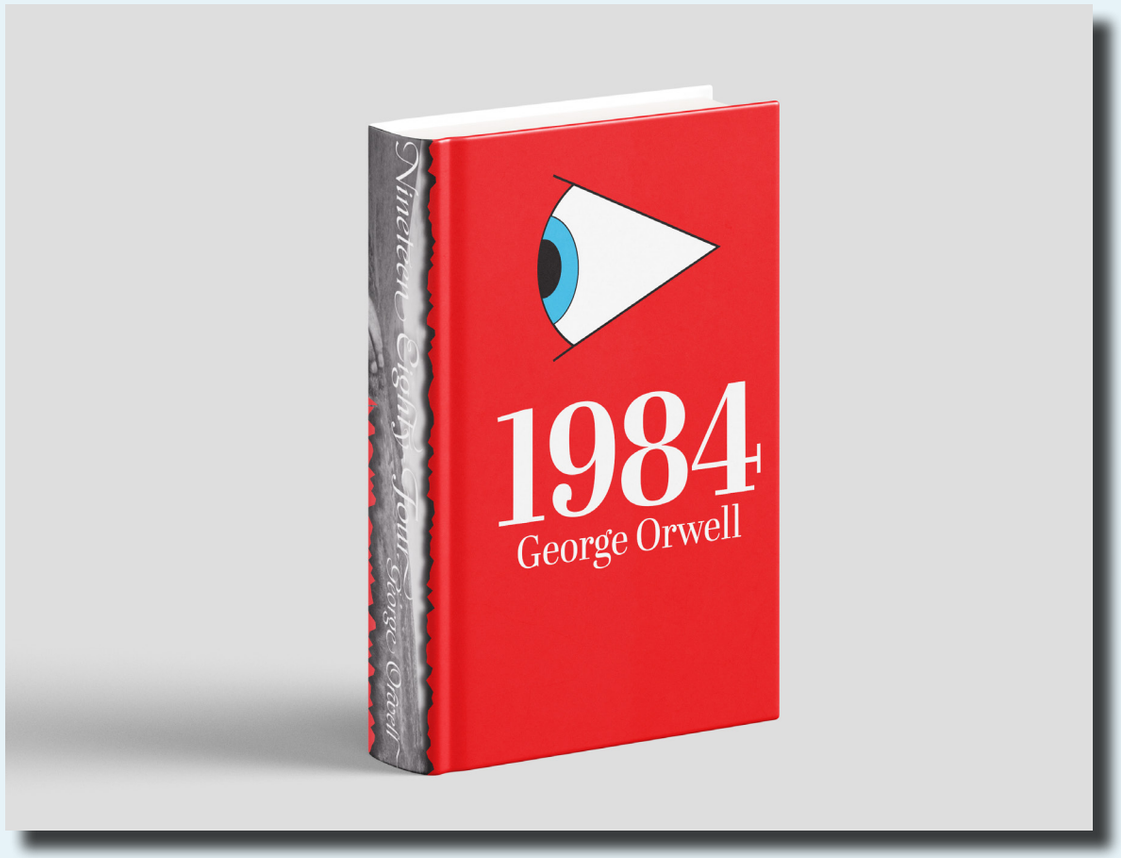


24| Delta Sigma Phi Branding

Logo embroidered onto shirts

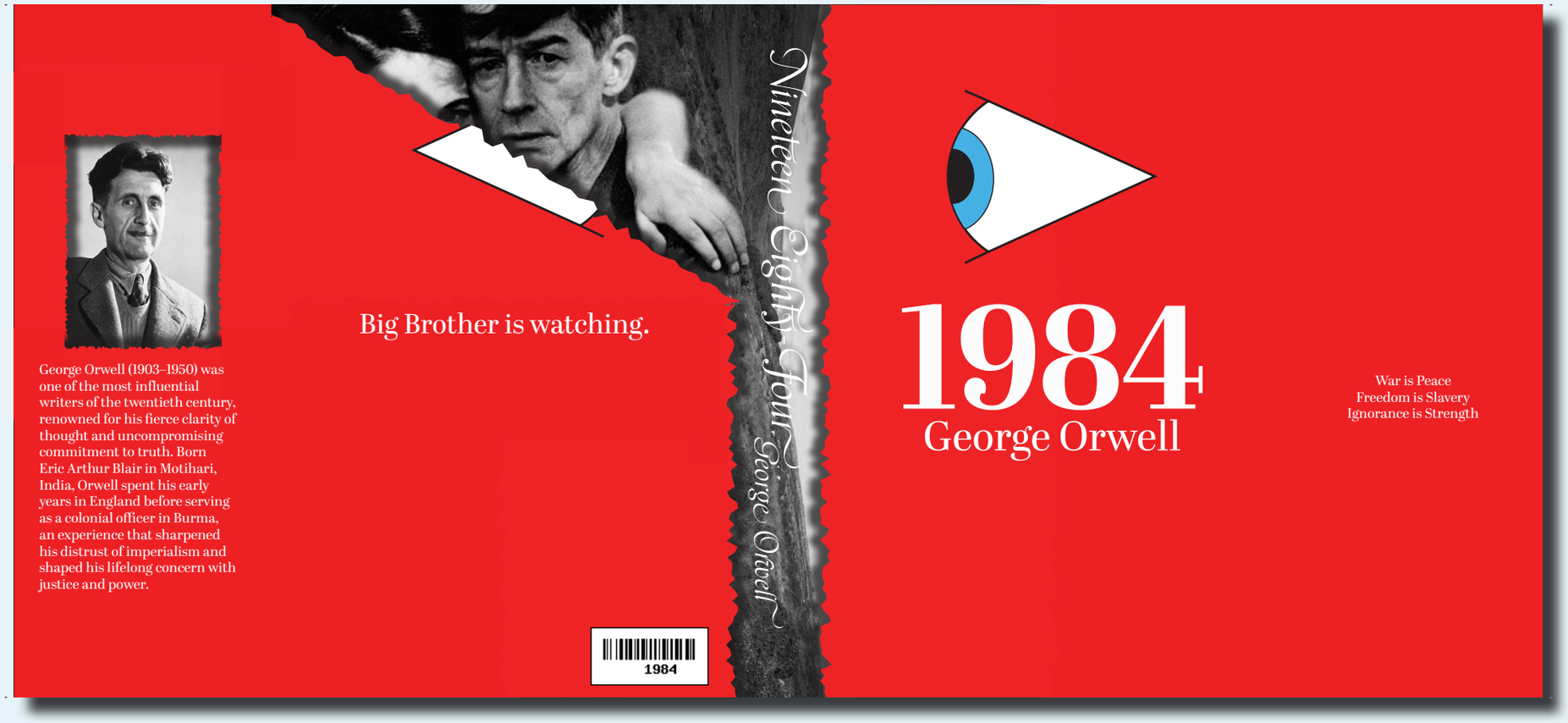
25 | 1984 Cover Redesign

Book Cover



26 | 1984 Cover Redesign

Book Cover



27 | Kai Hinz Award

Certificate

28 | Kai Hinz Award

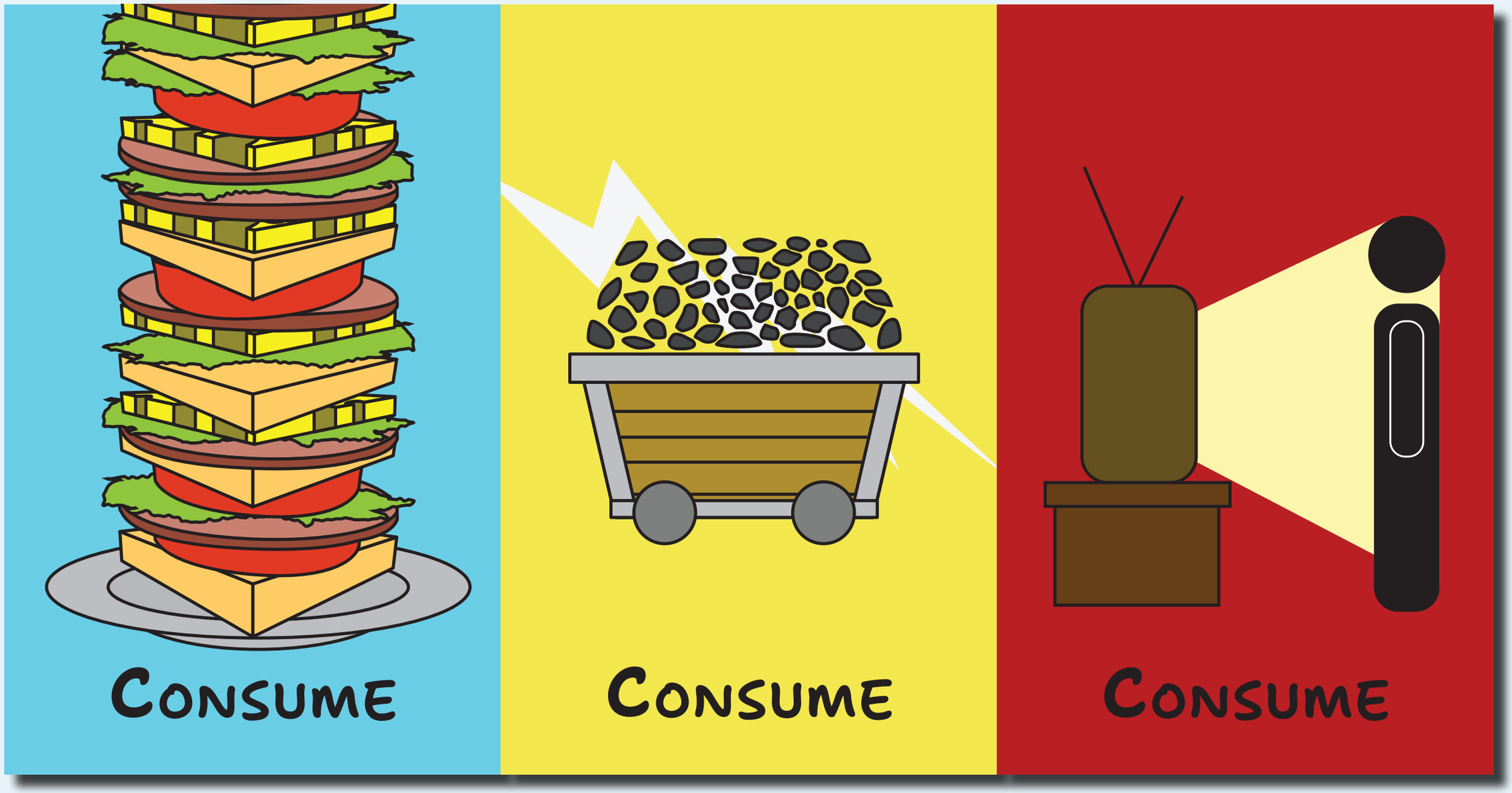
3D printed award

29 | Kai Hinz Award

Full mounted award

30 | “Consume” Posters

11” x 17” Posters



31 | Art Student Union Poster

8.5” x 11” Posters

32| Delta Sigma Phi Formal Ticket

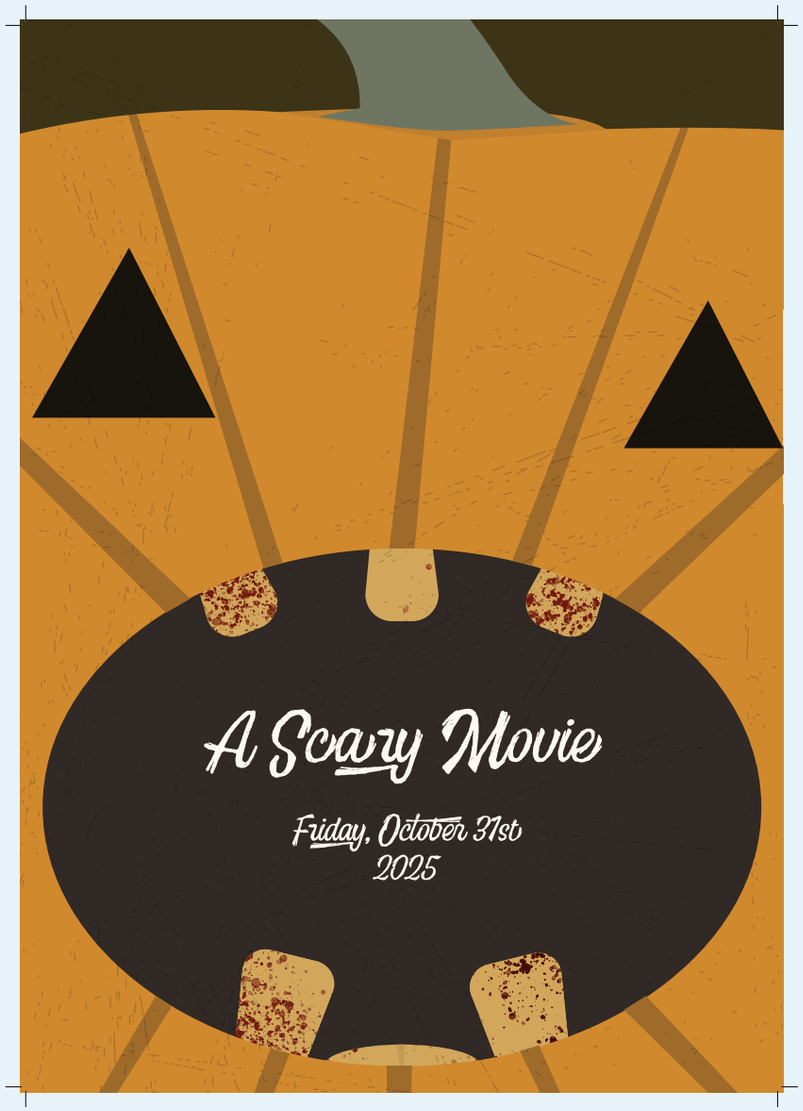
Double sided tickets for fraternity formal

33 | Delta Sigma Phi Formal Ticket

Double sided tickets for fraternity formal

34 | Spooky Halloween Poster

17” x 24” Poster for Central Minnesota American Advertising Foundation Halloween Poster Show



35 | Bryce's Menu

Menu created for a fictional resturant on the East Coast

Bryce's

Appetizers

Burrata (GF) 14
with SC Peach-Jalapeão Salsa, Balsamic Pearls, and Pistachios

SC Sautéed Shrimp (GF) 15
over Parmesan Polenta Cake and Citrus-Onion Marmalade

Lamb Carpaccio* (GF) 15
with Mint Pesto, Capers, Roasted Red Pepper Ricotta, Preserved Lemon Aioli, and Mustard Vinaigrette

Escargot 13
Burgundy Helix Snails, Cremini Mushrooms, Creamy Gorgonzola, and Crostini Pork Belly-

Sweet Potato Hash 18
with Fried Soft-Boiled Egg and Poblano Cream Sauce

Grilled Octopus (GF) 16
with Chorizo, Crispy Fingerling Potatoes, Olives, and Shishito Peppers over Roasted Red Bell Pepper Chimichurri

Artisan Cheese Plate 23
Chef's Nightly Selection of Artisan Cheeses and Accompaniments

Seared Foie Gras* (GF) 20
over Apple Chutney, Bacon Praline, and Cherry Gastrique

Fried Oysters 13
Florida Gulf Fried Oysters with Eggplant Agrodolce, Deviled Egg Aioli, and Bacon Powder

Crab & Avocado 16
Lump Crab Salad over Fried Avocado with Pickled Green Tomatoes and Hollandaise

Soups & Salad

Mixed Green Salad included with Main Course
Substitute Caesar Salad, Spinach Salad or Soup for an Additional $3

Soup of the Day 8

Mixed Greens 6
Lightly Tossed in a House Made Herb Vinaigrette

Traditional Caesar Salad 8
with Parmigiano-Reggiano and House Made Croutons Baby Spinach, Quail Egg and Warm Bacon-Maple Vinaigrette

Dress up your salad with:
- Feta Cheese 2
- Gorgonzola Cheese 2
- Pine Nuts 3
- Goat Cheese 2
- Hearts of Palm 2

Main courses

Cioppino 50
Sea Bass, Scallops, Crab, Shrimp, Clams, and Mussels in San Marzano Tomato Broth with Crostini

Pan Roasted Scottish Salmon* (GF) 36
with Jumbo Lump Crab, Sugar Snap Peas, Broccoli Rabe, and Dill Beurre Blanc

NC Day Boat Grouper and Lobster Tail (GF) 54
over Spinach and Saffron Risotto with Sherry-Lobster Beurre Blanc

Kurobuta Pork Chop* 44
with Arugula, Pickled Red Onion and Smoked Tomato-Bacon Vinaigrette over Sweet Corn-Gorgonzola Risotto

Elk Chop* 50
with Crispy Parmesan Yukon Gold Potatoes, Red Kuri Squash Puree, and Smoked Bacon, Blueberry, Balsamic Gastrique

Stilton-Crusted Filet Mignon* 62
with Polenta Cake, Caramelized Onions, Shiitake Mushrooms, and Haricots Verts

Veal Chop* (GF) 48
with Jumbo Shimp over Smashed Fingerling Potatoes, Cremini Mushrooms, Capers, Asparagus, and Sherry-Garlic Butter Sauce

Lamb Shank 45
over Fig Chutney Couscous with Rosemary Demi-glace, Garlic Breadcrumbs and Broccoli Rabe

Eggplant Ravioli 31
House Made Eggplant Ravioli with Sun-Dried Tomatoes, Zucchini, Yellow Squash, Portobello Mushrooms, with Gorgonzola Cream Sauce

*These items contain raw or undercooked ingredients. Consuming raw or undercooked meats, poultry, seafood, shellfish or eggs may increase your risk of foodborne illness.

36| Layout example

Example playing around with heiarchy

"PLACEMENT, ARRANGEMENT AND FORMATTING"

Sam Hampton-Smith

Grids

- Provide clear structure to the docuemnt
- Creates a connection between elements
- Allows for use of the rule of thirds

Heiarchy

- Have a clear structure for the different levels of heiarchy
- Headline should visually have more going on than body copy

Design

- Make use of white space
- Incorporation of negative space to balance out the information
- Repetition of elements can create balance in your design
- Create a main focal point

Balanced Design

Atributions to *The 7 secrets for creating balanced page layouts*